

Deputy CM Samrat Choudhary lays out roadmap for sports development, says change in mindset key



Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary highlighted the importance of a shift in mindset and moving away from the State's obsession with academics. R. V. MOORTHY



Bihar Sports Minister Surendra Mehta addressing the gathering during the Conclave. R. V. MOORTHY

The Honourable Deputy Chief Minister of Bihar, Samrat Choudhary, laid out the State government's vision for the development of sports during the Conclave.

The wheels of development were set in motion in January last year when Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar created a separate sports department. Until then, matters related to sports were handled by the art, culture and youth affairs department.

"Last January, we created a plan. Firstly, we decided to create a *khel gaon* in each of the nine divisions in the State that would cater to sports such as cricket, football and hockey.

"In many places, we have started the construction of stadiums. We hosted an international-level women's hockey tournament (Women's Asian Champions Trophy) in Rajgir.

"The whole world watched that tournament and it put the spotlight on the fact that Bihar can also host sports such as hockey," Choudhary said.

He also highlighted the importance of a shift in mindset and moving away from the State's obsession

with academics.

The recognition of the sports academy in Rajgir — which hosted the Women's Asian Champions Trophy last year — as a university by the Government of India was also a significant step for the development of sports in the State.

Choudhary also lauded the State government's 'Medal *Lao Naukri Pa'* scheme, which involves the direct recruitment of outstanding athletes from Bihar in government jobs.

With Bihar set to host the Women's Kabaddi World Cup, Khelo India Games, Under-20 Rugby Sevens Asian Championship and the Men's Hockey Asia Cup this year, Choudhary believes the future of sport in the State is bright.

"Just like Bihar has moved forward in education, CM Nitish Kumar is committed to ensure the children of Bihar also excel in sports," Choudhary concluded.

The Bihar Sports Minister Surendra Mehta who spoke on the occasion said that under the leadership of CM Nitish Kumar and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, sports was on the rise in the State.

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